In presenting herself to her devotees both as queen of the Cholas and (by implication) as consort to Lord Shiva, Sembiyan Mahadevi crossed the demarcation line between divinity and royalty, as if to make it clear that she herself should be regarded as quasi-divine. This was very much in accord with the Imperial Cholas' promotion of themselves as all-conquering kings or *chakravartin*, an ancient Sanskrit word that has its roots in the wheeled *chakra* and the chariot wheels of a conqueror that roll in every direction without meeting any resistance. Initially the Cholas had simply followed earlier models, taking their cue from the Gupta dynasty of kings who had earlier dominated Northern India and who had also seen themselves as all-powerful *chakravartin.* But precisely at the time of Sembiyan Mahadevi the Cholas dramatically upped the stakes by identifying themselves more intimately with Lord Shiva – and representing him in a striking and dramatic new form.

This leads us to another of the many temples with which our Chola queen Sembiyan Mahadevi was closely associated, albeit as restorer rather than builder, the Thillai Nataraja temple at Chidambaram, often spoken of by Tamil followers of Lord Shiva as the Golden Temple on account of its gilded roof – but also because of its supposed significance as the centre of the universe as occupied by Lord Shiva in the role of cosmic destroyer and recreator.

Chidambaram marks the penultimate step in the Cholas' northward advance towards the borders of Andhra, sited beside the most northerly of the many channels of the Cauvery River. What distinguishes this particular Shiva temple from virtually every other Shiva temple in India is its *murti*, the image of the deity that provides the main focus of worship. In the central shrine of virtually every Shiva temple you find a stone linga, a representation of the god in aniconic form which, as stated earlier, some Hindus consider an emblem of generative power while others argue that it is no more than a symbol of the formless Lord Shiva. Either